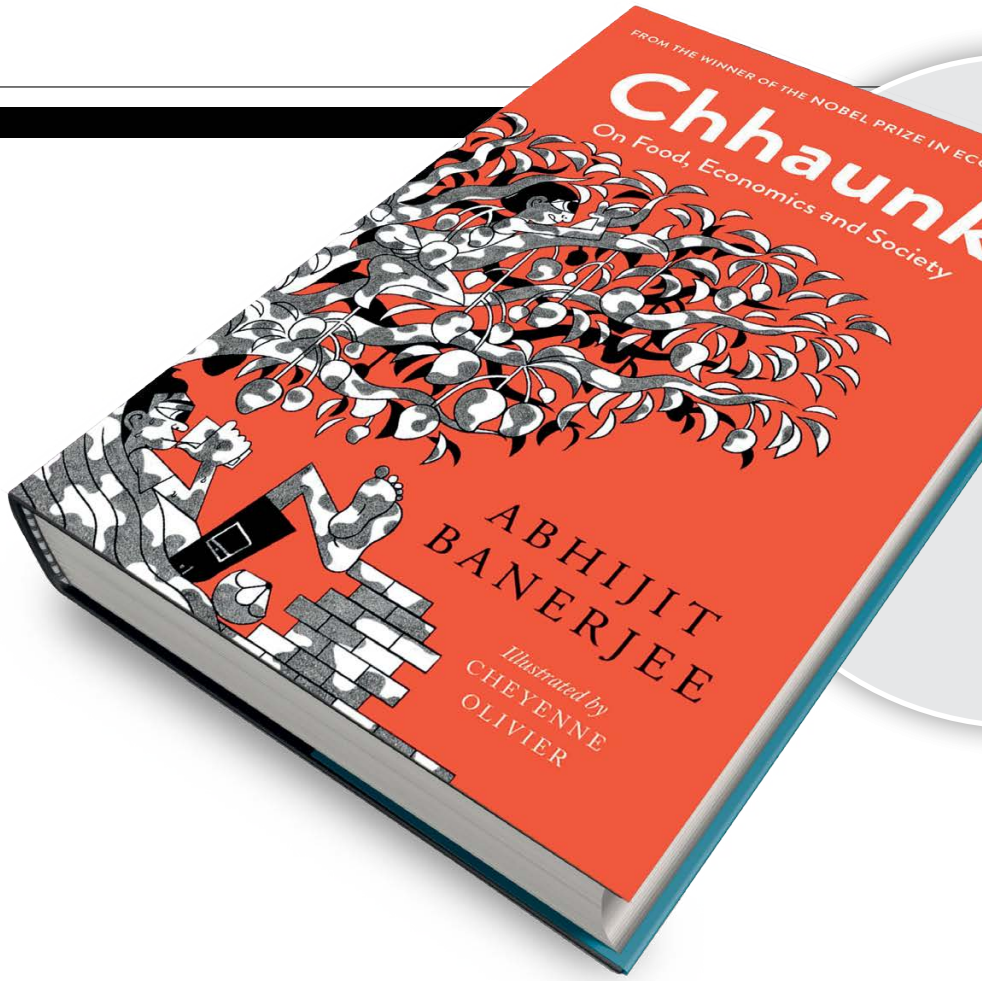




Abhijit Banerjee, Ford Foundation International Professor of Economics at MIT and the 2019 Nobel laureate in economic sciences, created quite a stir when he published a cookbook, *Cooking to Save Your Life*, in 2021, revealing a hitherto unknown facet of his personality, far removed from the stereotype of the absent-minded professor. With his latest book, *Chhaunk*, he marries what one can safely presume are two of his greatest interests—food and economics. While based on a monthly newspaper column he has been writing for the past two years, the book has the pieces arranged into three neat themes: 'Economics and Psychology', 'Economics and Culture', and 'Economics and Social Policy', with each section getting a fresh introduction. The columns were accompanied by his trademark recipes; for the book, many new ones have been added, which should keep Banerjee's fan base sated for a while. The evocative illustrations are by the talented Cheyenne Olivier, who has also illustrated Banerjee's previous book, as well as his wife Esther Duflo's *Poor Economics for Kids*.

BANERJEE IS PERHAPS UNUSUAL AMONG INDIAN MEN IN LEARNING TO COOK EARLY AND HELPING HIS MOTHER OUT IN THE KITCHEN AS A CHILD

Banerjee tackles a diversity of subjects in *Chhaunk*, from the intensely personal, like reminiscing about his mother who passed away in November 2023—"I miss her all the time"—to weightier concerns like inequality, nutrition and, of course, climate change. It's all peppered with interesting trivia, like the mention of the medieval "feast of the chestnuts, organised at the behest of Pope Cesare Borgia, where a hundred prostitutes were present".

"We rotate with three basic ingredients for the pieces—Abhijit's memories about India; economics, but more broadly social sciences; and then the food connection," explains Olivier. While the pieces, written with the general reader in mind, are digestible, they occasionally take on a more cerebral and thought-provoking tone. When the writing gets too heavy, Olivier—who, while nominally the illustrator, is really more a collaborator—reins Banerjee in. "Once I've written the text, she's the one who reads it carefully and often points out that this part is meant to be light, meant to be Sunday morning reading. There is a need for someone who's quite brutal, who'll say, no, that paragraph is too involved or academic or boring—and Cheyenne is not shy to say those things," adds Banerjee.

The recipes, drawn from diverse sources, are integral to each piece. "Often, while writing the piece, I'll plant some food ideas so there is a continuity between the piece and the recipes," says Banerjee. When asked how many of the recipes are entirely his creations, he muses, "Nothing ever is entirely anybody's. There are recipes here that are very traditional. There are recipes I've seen other people make. There's one called Akeela's Karela which was made by someone's cook in Patna and I stole it from her. We also have this goal of combining

